

Spanish Scrabble Winner Does Not Speak Spanish

A New Zealand man recently won an international Spanish Scrabble competition although he does not speak Spanish.

Scrabble is a board game in which players form words from letters to gain points.

Nigel Richards is a professional Scrabble player. He holds five English-language world championships in the board game. But in November, he won the Spanish world Scrabble championship in Granada, Spain. In the competition, he lost one game out of 24.

Many people are wondering how Richards could win without speaking Spanish.

Liz Fagerlund is a New Zealand Scrabble official and a friend of Richards. She recently told the Associated Press that Richards started memorizing the Spanish language Scrabble word list one year ago.

She said, “He can’t understand why other people can’t just do the same thing.” Fagerlund added, “He can look at a block of words together, and once they go into his brain as a picture he can just recall that very easily.”

FILE - Scrabble world champion Nigel Richards looks across the board before the start of his final round, Wednesday, Aug. 13, 2014, at the National Scrabble Championships in Buffalo, N.Y. (AP Photo/Gary Wiepert, File)

In second place was defending champion Benjamín Olaizola of Argentina. He won 18 of his games.

Nothing like the New Zealander’s win had ever happened in Spanish Scrabble, said Alejandro Terenzani, an organizer of the competition.

“It was impossible to react negatively, you can only be amazed,” Terenzani said. “We certainly expected that he would perform well, but it is perhaps true that he surpassed our expectations.”

However, the recent Scrabble competition is not the first that Richards has won in a language that he does not speak.

In 2015, he became the French language Scrabble world champion although he does not speak French. He studied the French language word list for nine weeks. He won the French championship again in 2018.

Richards is known in the world of international Scrabble as the greatest player of all time. He has been playing in competitions for about 30 years. But other players have said his Spanish language victory was notable even by his standards.

Playing Spanish Scrabble required some different methods to win. The wooden pieces, or tiles, used in the word game have different values in English and Spanish Scrabble. Richards also had to consider thousands of additional seven-, eight- and nine-letter words in the Spanish language.

FILE - Claire Miklaucic, from Charlotte, N.C., plays a word during the first round of the 2015 North American School SCRABBLE Championship, at Hasbro headquarters in Pawtucket, R.I., Saturday, May 16, 2015. (Stew Milne/AP Images for Hasbro)

In 2008, Richards was the first player ever to hold the world, U.S., and British titles at the same time. He had to “forget” 40,000 English words that do not appear in the American Scrabble word list to win in the U.S.

His victories are famous in the Scrabble community. Tens of thousands of people have watched and analyzed his games in YouTube videos.

Scrabble does not require players to know the definitions of words. Players only need to know what combinations of letters can be used in a country’s version of the game.

Native speakers have “a huge leg up,” American Scrabble player Will Anderson said in a video explaining Richards’ Spanish win.

In 2010, Richards’ mother, Adrienne Fischer, told a New Zealand newspaper that he was not a great English student in school. He never attended university. And he took a mathematical approach to the game rather than a linguistic one.

“I don’t think he’s ever read a book,” she said, “apart from the dictionary.”

Fagerlund said Richards impressed her when he arrived at his first Scrabble club meeting at age 28. Two years later, in 1997, he rode a bicycle 350 kilometers from Christchurch to the city of Dunedin where he won the New Zealand championship on his first try. Then he rode the bicycle home again.

At the Spanish event, he was shy and modest, organizer Terenzani said. But he happily had his picture taken and spoke with fans who sought him out.

“Although he did so in English, of course,” Terenzani joked.

Richards now lives in Malaysia. He never speaks to reporters. What drives him is a mystery.

“I get lots of requests from journalists wanting to interview him, and he’s not interested,” Fagerlund said.

She added that he does not understand what all the fuss is about.

I'm Anna Matteo.

Charlotte Graham-McLay reported this story for the Associated Press. Anna Matteo adapted it for VOA Learning English.

Vocabulary

block - n. กลุ่มหรือชุดของบางสิ่ง

recall - v. จำได้ ระลึกได้

negatively - adv. ในทางที่ไม่ดี ไม่เป็นประโยชน์ หรือไม่มีความสุข

amazed - adj. ประหลาดใจหรือชื่นชมอย่างมาก

surpass - v. เหนือกว่า เกินกว่า

standards - n. (พหูพจน์) ระดับของความคาดหวังที่เกี่ยวข้องกับคุณสมบัติหรือเงื่อนไขหลายประการ

linguistic - adj. ที่เกี่ยวกับภาษา

leg up - สำนวน. สิ่งที่ช่วยให้คนทำบางสิ่งได้ดีกว่าคนอื่น

impressed - adj. ทำให้ประทับใจ

shy - adj. ขี้อาย ไม่เต็มใจหรือไม่กล้าพูดคุยกับผู้อื่นด้วยเหตุผลบางอย่าง

modest - adj. ถ่อมตัว ไม่ต้องการเป็นจุดสนใจหรือไม่แสดงความกังวลมากเกินไปเกี่ยวกับบุคลิกของตนเอง

fuss - n. ความวุ่นวาย การแสดงความชื่นชมหรือความสนใจมากเกินไปที่อาจไม่จริงจัง

Reading Comprehension Quiz

1. What surprising achievement did a New Zealand man recently accomplish?

He won an international Spanish language competition by speaking fluently.

He won an international Spanish Scrabble competition despite not speaking Spanish.

He became a professional Spanish Scrabble player after one year of study.

He translated Spanish vocabulary definitions into Thai for a VOA article.

2. Besides his recent Spanish Scrabble championship, what other notable achievements does Nigel Richards hold?

He holds five French-language world championships in Scrabble.

He is a professional Scrabble player with five English-language world championships.

He has won 24 games out of 24 in a competition.

He only competes in English-language Scrabble events.

3. How did Nigel Richards prepare for the Spanish Scrabble competition, according to Liz Fagerlund?

He learned to speak Spanish fluently in one year.

He spent one year memorizing the Spanish language Scrabble word list.

He practiced playing Scrabble with Spanish native speakers.

He studied Spanish grammar and sentence structure.

4. What unique ability does Nigel Richards possess regarding word memorization?

He can understand the meaning of any word just by looking at it.

He can recall words very easily once they enter his brain as a picture.

He believes others cannot do the same thing he does.

He requires detailed explanations for word memorization.

5. Who was the runner-up in the Spanish world Scrabble championship and what was his performance?

Alejandro Terenzani, who won 18 games.

Benjamín Olaizola of Argentina, who won 18 of his games.

Nigel Richards, who lost only one game.

An unnamed defending champion from Spain.

6. What was significant about Nigel Richards' win in the Spanish Scrabble competition, according to Alejandro Terenzani?

It was a common occurrence in Spanish Scrabble.

It was the first time such an event had ever happened in Spanish Scrabble.

It showed that Richards speaks Spanish fluently.

It was predicted by all the organizers from the start.

7. What was the reaction of the competition organizer, Terenzani, to Richards' performance?

He was upset that Richards, a non-Spanish speaker, won.

He was surprised and amazed, stating Richards surpassed their expectations.

He expected Richards to win comfortably from the beginning.

He reacted negatively, questioning the fairness of the competition.

8. What other major non-native language Scrabble championship has Richards won before the Spanish one?

He won the German language Scrabble world championship.

He won the French language Scrabble world championship in 2015 and 2018.

He studied the French language word list for nine years.

He only started competing in non-native language championships recently.

9. How is Nigel Richards generally regarded in the world of international Scrabble?

He is known as a good player, but his Spanish victory was his only major surprise.

He is considered the greatest player of all time, despite his recent controversial wins.

He is known as the greatest player of all time, and his Spanish victory was notable even for him.

He has only been playing in competitions for about 10 years.

10. What challenges did Nigel Richards face specifically when playing Spanish Scrabble compared to English Scrabble?

He had to learn a completely new set of game rules and strategies.

He needed to master Spanish grammar for constructing sentences.

The wooden tiles had different values, and he had to consider thousands of additional words.

Spanish Scrabble allowed him to use fewer letters, making it easier.

11. What significant achievement did Richards accomplish in 2008, and what did it entail?

He won the U.S. and British titles but lost the world title.

He was the first player to hold the world, U.S., and British titles simultaneously, requiring him to forget 40,000 English words.

He learned 40,000 new English words to win in the U.S.

He started his professional Scrabble career in 2008.

12. What is a fundamental requirement for players in Scrabble?

Players must be native speakers of the language.

Players must know the definitions of all words they use.

Players only need to know what letter combinations are valid in a country's version of the game.

Players are required to have a linguistic background.

13. How did Nigel Richards approach the game of Scrabble, according to his mother?

He excelled in English literature and language studies at university.

He took a linguistic approach, focusing on word origins and grammar.

He adopted a mathematical approach rather than a linguistic one, and never attended university.

He was an avid reader of books, especially dictionaries.

14. What event marked Nigel Richards' entry into the competitive Scrabble world and his early success?

He won his first Scrabble club meeting at age 28.

He rode a bicycle 350 kilometers to win the New Zealand championship on his first try, two years after joining a club.

He impressed Liz Fagerlund by winning a national championship before joining a club.

He became a world champion within two years of starting Scrabble.

15. Which of the following statements accurately describes Nigel Richards' personal characteristics and public interaction?

He is very outgoing and enjoys speaking with reporters about his victories.

He is shy and modest, does not speak to reporters, and doesn't understand the fuss about his achievements.

He now lives in Spain and actively seeks out fans for conversations.

He is known for speaking multiple languages fluently with fans.